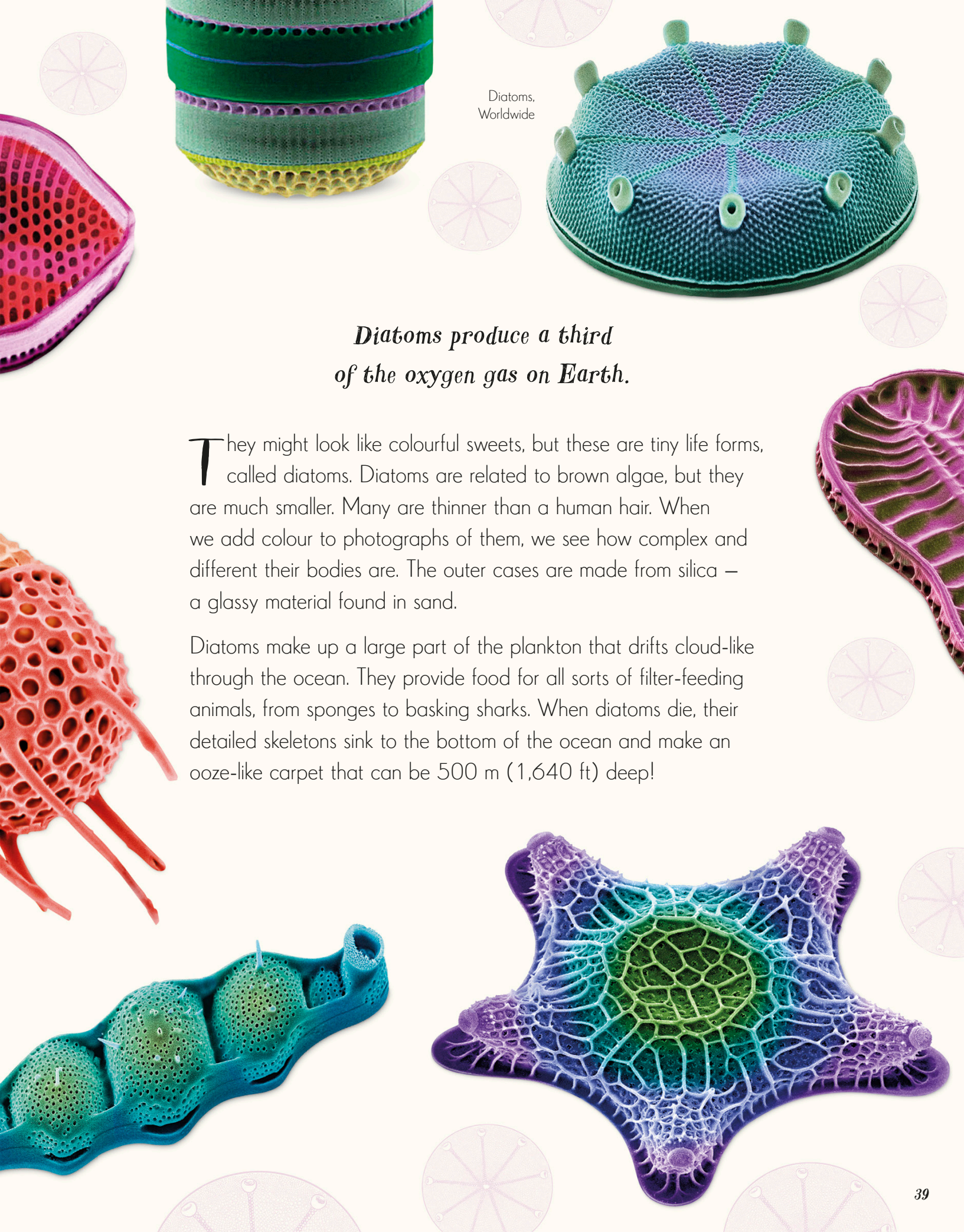




Diatoms,  
Worldwide

*Diatoms produce a third  
of the oxygen gas on Earth.*

They might look like colourful sweets, but these are tiny life forms, called diatoms. Diatoms are related to brown algae, but they are much smaller. Many are thinner than a human hair. When we add colour to photographs of them, we see how complex and different their bodies are. The outer cases are made from silica – a glassy material found in sand.

Diatoms make up a large part of the plankton that drifts cloud-like through the ocean. They provide food for all sorts of filter-feeding animals, from sponges to basking sharks. When diatoms die, their detailed skeletons sink to the bottom of the ocean and make an ooze-like carpet that can be 500 m (1,640 ft) deep!